

LABOUR

'Section 144' at IMT Manesar: Police Violence Against Protesting Maruti Workers Intensifies Ahead of Tripartite Meet, Violates Court Order

Haryana police deployed in force on 29th-30th January 2025 to disrupt the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh's planned mass demonstration at IMT Manesar — invoking Section 144 of the now-obsolete IPC despite a court order permitting the gathering. A photo essay and press release from the scene.

BY MOULI SHARMA



Photo: Mouli Sharma

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MEDIA

“He was the Personification of Bravery”: Lauded National Journalist Deepankar Ghose Remembers Mukesh Chandrakar, Criticises Treatment of Regional Reporters

Dipankar Ghose, Deputy National Editor at Hindustan Times, remembers his friend Mukesh Chandrakar — the Bastar-based journalist found dead in a septic tank at the property of a contractor he had exposed — in an 18-part eulogy on X that speaks to the unequal risks borne by regional and independent reporters in India.

BY DIPANKAR GHOSE



Photo: Dipankar Ghose

Following is Hindustan Times' Deputy National Editor, Dipankar Ghose's 18 part eulogy on X for Bastar based journalist, Mukesh Chandrakar, who was found dead in a septic tank at the property of a construction contractor he had earlier exposed for corruption. Ghose highlights the disproportionate risks faced by regional & independent journalists in India.

5th January 2025: How do you begin to write a tribute to a journalist, a friend, a brother? How do you describe him when nothing really contains him? The first time I met Mukesh Chandrakar was in December 2015, weeks after I had landed in Chhattisgarh as the Indian Express reporter there.

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Members of the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh (MSAMS), were arrested & forcibly dispersed from their protest site at IMT Manesar ahead of their mass demonstration against the company management, for which they had sought & recieved the local Court's permission. Despite the favourable court order, officers of the Manesar, Gurgaon & Pataudi police were deployed in large numbers to disrupt the workers' gathering, claiming an imposition of Section 144 of the now obsolete IPC. Police declined to comment on the situation, & even threatened to detain media persons present on site. Following is the official press release of the MSAMS.

January 30, 2025: IMT Manesar remained the scene of widespread chaos throughout 29th and 30th January as the Haryana police lay siege over Manesar tehsil, the site for a massive demonstration and march of non-permanent workers of Maruti Suzuki challenging the system of hire-and-fire of workers and demanding permanent jobs, equal pay, and other facilities for temporary workers at par with permanent workers. The unmeasured unleashing of repression on peaceful protesters indicates how threatened the Maruti Suzuki management feels by any questions being raised about its hire and fire labour policies, the main source of its massive profits. It also revealed the hand and glove coordination of the company and the local administration.

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Seeking to preempt the gathering, the administration imposed Section 144 around Manesar Tehsil on the evening of January 29. The following morning, thousands of workers pouring into the area for the protest were packed into buses and taken to the Manesar police lines station or let off at different locations 40-50 km from the protest site. Others were chased through fields with lathis.

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"He was the Personification of Bravery": Lauded Nation · CONTINUED
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Dipankar Ghose is a WHT Scholar from the University of Oxford. He is presently the Deputy National Editor at Hindustan Times. In 2015, he met Mukesh while covering a story in Bastar. Image Courtesy: Weidenfeld-Hoffmann Trust, University of Oxford
Photo: Dipankar Ghose

There was a story in Bastar, and I had reached Bijapur, one of India's most dangerous places to report, with very little to go on. There I was, at the district headquarters, in a run-down press club building among a group of journalists eyeing me suspiciously.

The suspicion of "national journalists" is warranted. Very often, we climb on the shoulders of our regional colleagues, leave them to danger, or worse forget we know them. The story spot was deep inside the forests, some 80 kilometres away.

I asked loudly, sheepishly, if someone would come with me tomorrow. By come with me, I meant take me. In that moment, I was helpless. There was only one voice that said "Haan, kal challenge aapke saath."

I went back to the relative comfort of my hotel in Jagdalpur. Mukesh went to the mechanic shop to repair his motorcycle for what lay ahead. The next day, at the agreed 5 am, we met at the Bijapur bus stop(there was no network except BSNL in Bastar in 2015), and set off.

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He was young, but he was my first teacher in Bastar. He taught me the dangers of relieving yourself on the sides of a freshly laid road,because that's where an IED would be. He taught me to stand up on the back of a bike to ensure that your muscles don't spasm under duress.

We navigated paved roads, and then unpaved roads, and then no roads. Carried the motorcycle across streams. Waded through mud. He told me how to navigate a complicated world of hostile police, hostile Maoists, and beleaguered people.

It was an important story, and the state took note. But the byline said my name, not his. Mukesh did this over and over again. Not just for me, but for many others. It was on his back that the stories of Bijapur, of lives lived in conflict, were ever told.

For me, Mukesh was the personification of bravery. I'm not going to pretend that in a universe where media organisations he worked for didn't even pay for his petrol let alone a stable salary, sustenance wasn't a problem, and therefore some wires weren't crossed.

LABOUR

'Equal Work, Equal Pay': 'Temporary' Maruti-Suzuki Workers Establish Union, Join Hands With Protesting Terminated Workers

The official press release of the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh — founded on 5th January 2025 in a mass meeting of over three thousand non-permanent workers at Gurgaon — announcing the union's formation, its charter of demands, and its solidarity with the already-protesting terminated workers.

BY MOULI SHARMA



Photo: Mouli Sharma

LABOUR

"Not Your Footballs!" Newly Formed Union of Non-Permanent Maruti-Suzuki Employees Intensifies Agitation, Calls Out Abuse of Contract Workers

Thousands of current and former non-permanent Maruti-Suzuki workers gathered at the Gurgaon DC office on 10th January 2025 to submit their charter of demands — challenging the company's hire-and-fire labour practices and demanding equal pay and permanent employment alongside the already-protesting terminated workers.

BY MOULI SHARMA



Photo: Mouli Sharma

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Photo: Mouli Sharma

Afternoon, 30th January 2025: A young worker travelling from overstate is detained along with his luggage. After the arrest of senior movement leaders from the terminated workers' movement in the morning, the police began a second round of detentions in the afternoon. Image courtesy: Mouli Sharma for TVE

A team of workers has also gone to Chandigarh to move the High Court against the imposition of Sec 144 and the disregard of the lower court's order recognizing the right of workers to protest peacefully 500m away from the plant premises.

Not being allowed to gather in IMT Manesar today, workers are set to regroup in front of the labour department at the DC office in Gurgaon tomorrow, on the morning of January 31, for the second meeting of the tripartite negotiation on the CoD submitted on January 10. A team of workers has also gone to Chandigarh to move the High Court against the imposition of Sec 144 and the disregard of the lower court's order recognizing the right of workers to protest peacefully 500m away from the plant premises.

The sham of skill
development

Press Release, Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh . Contact: 9911258717, 9958426959, 9671705166, 9990115799, 9050073578. Facebook: @Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh, YouTube: @Maruti_Suzuki_Asthayi_Mazdoor

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But Mukesh loved journalism with a passion. When he was with you, nothing was impossible. He was always compassionate to people he reported on, always empathetic. He was rooted in Bastar, but not limited by it.

After a decade of jumping from one channel to the other, he realised organisations would never truly value its ground reporters in the region. He recognized the power of technology, and started Bastar Junction, a YouTube channel that at last count has 162K followers.

Go to YouTube now and watch his videos, and you will find more journalism than screaming television studios can ever offer. He reported from spots of attacks, crossed forests and mountains to get to victims of violence, reported from police camps, and from Naxal camps.

Journalism in Bastar has risks, and he bore them all. Getting to a spot is more physically arduous, more dangerous than most can imagine. Maoists threatened his life several times; the state threatened him when he exposed excess.

He was often bullied by his own Bijapur fraternity for helping "national journalists" but he never, ever wavered. It was him, and my other dear friend Ganesh Mishra, who risked their lives and went deep into the forests to rescue a CRPF Jawan abducted by Maoists.

But Bastar claimed him. On December 24, Mukesh reported on a shoddily built road in Bijapur--an obvious case of corruption. The story caused an enquiry. A week later, Mukesh was found dead, buried inside a septic tank in the home of the contractor that built that road.

The last time I met him was during the Chhattisgarh elections, when I spent the day with him and Ganesh Mishra. We reported, talked and laughed for hours. And then Mukesh took me home because he had cooked some lunch for me himself.

We laughed and lamented my distance from Bastar, and friends like the two of them. His last message to me, in October, had the words "Pata nahi kab mulakat hogi, par mulakat ka intezaar humesha rahega." I told him, "jald hogi mulakat."

How does one begin to remember him? As a journalist? As a bridge to Bastar? As the voice of those that would never be heard otherwise? Remember him as them all. To me, he was Mukesh Chandrakar, my friend, my brother. Go well, bhai. Mulaqaat ka humesha intezaar rahega.

"Not Your Footballs!" Newly Formed Union of Non-Perman · CONTINUED
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Following is the official press release of the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Workers Sangh for their demonstration outside the DC office in Rajiv Chowk, Gurgaon on the 10th of January 2025 , where thousands of workers from several states joined those in Haryana, which has been the epicentre of the Maruti Movement since 2011. The agitation of Non-Permanent workers started on 5th January, and stands hand in hand with the already protesting terminated workers union, the Maruti Workers Sturggle Committee, which has been on an indefinite strike near the company's Manesar plant since September 18th 2024.

January 10, Gurgaon: Thousands of current and erstwhile non-permanent workers of Maruti Suzuki gathered at the Gurgaon DC office to submit their collective charter of demands to the Labour Department challenging the illegal labour practices of the company. The workers have organised themselves under the Maruti Suzuki Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh, launched on the 5th of January, 2025 in a mass meeting held at Krishna Chowk, Gurgaon. The charter of demands was also submitted to the company management on January 9, 2025.

The labour department has scheduled a tripartite meeting with the company management and the Sangh on January 31, 2025. The demonstration also submitted a memorandum to the Chief Minister of Haryana and declared a massive mobilization and workers march in IMT Manesar on the 30th of January. A working committee of non-permanent workers from different states and representatives from among the Maruti terminated workers is leading the agitation. The workers have demanded an end to the reliance on various categories of temporary workers for regular production in all plants of the automobile giant. They are demanding permanent employment for work of a permanent nature, equal pay for equal work, hiring of temporary workers previously and presently employed by the company to all the plants as permanent workers including the new plant in Kharkhoda, Sonipat and ensuring useful and recognized training of Maruti Student trainees and apprentices. Non-permanent workers arriving into the area for the agitation have been camping at the protest site of terminated Maruti Workers at the Manesar Tehsil near IMT Manesar Chowk, seven kilometers from the company gate. "Workers are not footballs to be kicked out at your whim!" Sumit, a temporary worker from Bahadurgarh gave the movement its defining metaphor of temporary workers being footballs kicked around from company to company. The image comes from his own 12 year long experience in the automobile industry where he has worked in the Hero car plant in Noida and the Hero bike plant in Manesar besides various stints in Maruti Suzuki.

"All power is held by the management, we cannot even voice our demands peacefully!"



Photo: Mouli Sharma

Evening, 29th january 2025: A police officer smiles for the camera outside IMT Manesar, which had been the protest & campsite of the terminated & temporary Maruti workers for over 4 months since the former began their infinite strike on 18th September last year. After the detentions on Wednesday morning, the tents were destroyed & cleared by the Haryana police, & workers have since been unable to return for fear of capture. Image courtesy: Mouli Sharma for TVE

The Maruti Suzuki management has now approached the Gurgaon civil court twice, first asking for a permanent injunction against the terminated workers and now an injunction against the temporary workers. In both instances, the court recognized the right of workers to demonstrate peacefully 500m away from the company gate and boundary. However, as soon as the court pronounced its orders on the morning of January 29, the police started uprooting the demonstration site of the workers in front of Manesar tehsil.

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Khushiram, a worker terminated in 2012 and legal advisor of the Asthayi Mazdoor Sangh spoke to local media on the night of 29th January, “We have never gone against the law, while the company has flouted all labour laws and destroyed the lives of over 11 lakh workers over the last 13 years. Yet at the behest of the management, the police have even refused to respect the order of the Gurgaon court.” The Maruti Suzuki management has now approached the Gurgaon civil court twice, first asking for a permanent injunction against the terminated workers and now an injunction against the temporary workers. In both instances, the court recognized the right of workers to demonstrate peacefully 500m away from the company gate and boundary. However, as soon as the court pronounced its orders on the morning of January 29, the police started uprooting the demonstration site of the workers in front of Manesar tehsil.

“Not going back without the jobs we deserve”:
Maruti temporary workers



Photo: Mouli Sharma

Late Morning, 30th January 2025: After the first round of arrests, workers who had travelled from neighbouring states felt disheartened & fearful for their safety as well as that of their detained fellows, but their desire to continue the mobilisation ahead of tomorrow's meeting remained absolute. Image courtesy: Mouli Sharma for TVE

Workers argue that while the company has constantly expanded its sales and profits, the workers who have made this possible have been left out in the cold with no security of employment and labour rights. The company presently employs 83% of its labour force on short-term contracts which state that “Your appointment is purely temporary in nature and has arisen due to fluctuating business and exigencies of work.” Only 5713 permanent workers out of the total workforce of 34,918 enjoy the benefits and high salaries that the company claims to provide its workers. The company has been recruiting workers directly after school in the name of running an ITI and conducting skill development, others are recruited as temporary workers (TW) for 7-month-long contracts, and many others as contract workers for similar tenures ranging from a few months to a couple of years. Workers are promised to be called for another tenure after some time if they maintain full attendance and work without any complaints. However, not more than a handful are called for a second or third term. Thousands of workers are called for the Company trainee (CT) exam which is seen as a doorway to permanency every year, but only 30-40 workers are finally made permanent across the three plants. This process keeps workers engaged in an on-and-off way through the best years of their lives, i.e. from 18 to 25 after which there is no hope for being recruited again. The experience letter and training certificate provided by the company hold no value in the job market as the workers are placed directly in production and spend their entire time on only one or two stations, gaining no definite skills.



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